

**The top of the Taj Mahal’s dome**

**The Yamuna River and the Moonlight Garden**

Behind the Taj Mahal flows the next element of the site's design: the Yamuna River. While not as famous as the Ganges, the Yamuna (also called the Jumna) River is one of Hinduism's sacred waterways and was an important artery for the traffic of the Mughal Empire, because it flows down from the Himalayas and passes Delhi. Then, as now, the city was the capital - in fact, it had been extensively rebuilt by Shah Jahan - and the proximity of this city was undoubtedly important for the symbolism of the Taj[38]. The Yamuna continued to flow southeast from the capital, flowing past Agra and then winding its way until finally joining the mighty Ganges near Allahabad[39].

Modern observers often compare the rivers of the pre-modern world to highways, but this unfortunately falls short. Today’s highways carry travelers and goods efficiently from place to place, which was certainly one of the roles of the rivers, but rivers were also the carriers of information and control in the